

The Protectors

The founders of the 2,000-strong National Anti-Hack Group, and why they would rather guard what they could so easily destroy

Nimish Chandiramani

"Is your port 80 wide open?" the Web site ominously asks. In these paranoid times where wars are fought in cyberspace and anybody could be a victim, who will stand against the forces of e-vil? Who will protect you from the malicious being that is the hacker? And when will we stop with these corny clichés?

There's probably no answer to the last question, but in 2003, two young men sat up and decided to be the answer to the others. In the face of increasing attacks on Indian Web sites, Vineet Kumar and Rakesh Sharma decided to form a community of ethical hackers (or White Hats, as they now call themselves) to secure the country from cyber attacks—the National Anti-Hack Group (NAG). Both are highly skilled hackers, and they do it because "only hackers can prevent hack attacks," as they say.

The Plot

At the alarmingly young age of 18, Vineet Kumar from Ranchi is now managing director and the face of NAG. His interest in cyber security and hacking goes a long way back, and during his activities in hacking groups online, he met Rakesh Sharma (now 23), then a student of computer engineering in Rajasthan. Predictably enough, the two found a common ground, and numerous—no doubt healthy—conversations later, they decided to form an organisation dedicated to protecting Indian Web sites from malicious attack. They would encourage and nurture budding hackers, making them use their powers for good, so to speak.

Enter Anup Girdhar, an independent security consultant, who, during the course of a seminar he was taking at IIT Delhi in 2004, was



Illustration Chaitanya Surpur
3D Modelling Vikram Kathare